

Their first viral hit came with a demo for *simuyier payesh* (vermicelli pudding). One day, Suprabha asked her to taste the food on camera and react. "Daarun!" (wonderful), she smiled—a word that is their signature now. The dream now? To open a café—perhaps in Kolkata, but more likely in Digha, Usha's windy hometown by the sea. ■

Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

WHAT IS CREATOR ECONOMY?

It is a collective of creators, platforms (Instagram, YouTube, Snapchat et al), brands and third-party intermediaries like talent management agencies who come together to generate revenue via content-driven models such as advertising, sponsorships, subscriptions, commerce, live-streaming, among other things

4.6

MILLION

Strength of creators in India in 2024, according to the Goat India Influencer Marketing Report, 2025

₹30-34

LAKH CRORE

Creator-fuelled consumption/ creator-influenced spend in 2024, as per a BCG report titled 'Mapping India's Creator Economy'

₹3,600

CRORE

Value of the Indian influencer marketing industry in 2024, according to the Goat report

₹1.7-2

LAKH CRORE

Size of India's creator economy, as per the BCG report

in time spent online—1.1 trillion hours in 2024 as per consulting firm EY, an average of five hours a day glued to mobile screens, of which 70 per cent is spent on social media, video platforms and gaming. The most populous nation in the world also makes the highest number of Instagram reels and has the most YouTube channels (over 100 million, with over 15,000 having over a million subscribers). Little wonder that digital channels eclipsed TV to emerge as the biggest segment of the media and entertainment (M&E) industry, generating Rs 80,200 crore in revenues in 2024.

India's creator economy is now seen as a sizeable part of the M&E ecosystem. At the recent World Audio Visual and Entertainment Summit (WAVES) in Mumbai, creators and digital platforms were as much the centre of attraction as Bollywood celebrities. TechnicalGuruji aka Gaurav Chaudhary moderated a panel, food and travel influencer Kamiya Jani aka Curly Tales was part of one; and there was Creatorsphere, a pavilion devoted to the fast-growing industry. In his opening speech, Prime Minister Narendra Modi hailed the creator community, saying, "As the orange economy booms, I will tell every young creator in India, whether you are a musician in Guwahati, a podcaster in Kochi or designing a game in Bengaluru, you are all bringing a wave in Indian economy, a wave of creativity." He also met the 750+ finalists of the Create in India Challenge and announced the establishment of an Indian Institute of Creative Technology in Mumbai, to train a new generation of creators with new skills.

Anybody Can Be a Creator

"You can say that India has become a creator nation without batting an eyelid," says Ajay Vidyasagar, managing director, YouTube South East Asia and Emerging Markets. "The sheer energy and speed at which Indian creators are finding their voice and thereon succeeding on a platform like YouTube is extraordinarily inspiring." In 2022-2024, YouTube paid Rs 21,000 crore to those who create content in India: a sector that includes not just traditional media giants but also a burgeoning band of solo creators and artists. It plans to invest Rs 850 crore in the coming two years to accelerate growth. The magic of India's content creation revolution, feels